the ill-fated Women's Reservation Bill seems modest. An attempt to feminise Indian politics on such a scale is a strikingly novel manoeuvre. The AICC general secretary in charge of UP, still only learning to swim in the deep, can't be faulted for her math. Women make up over 46 per cent of the population in UP. Can they be persuaded to vote as women? Over and above conflicting loyalties such as religion, caste and ideology?

This season's harvest may doubtless be slim, but Priyanka has sallied forth on the conviction that these are good questions to ask for the future (*see interview*). The logic is impeccable. Parties have often tapped into this demographic—but only via tactically designed handout politics, "pro-women" policies like prohibition, or plain tokenism. No one has much talked the language of direct empowerment.

That's the catchword in Priyanka's lexicon. To be sure, there's room for it. Quite a few of India's women politicians inherit politics—Priyanka herself, for one. Many of those not born into it are married into it. And then there are celebrity faces in all parties. By contrast, the 50 women in the Congress's first list of 125 candidates include a rape victim's mother, an activist who was jailed for some three weeks during the anti-CAA agitation, an ASHA worker who led an agitation for a raise in honorarium for her vastly underpaid sorority, and a district-level leader who was sexually assaulted during local elections. Remember the names, one might say for effect: Asha Singh from Unnao, Lucknow's Sadaf Jafar, Poonam Pandey from Shahjahanpur and Ritu Singh from Lakhimpur Kheri, in that order. Real women, daughters of the earth who have held up half the sky in a violent society. They join others like news anchor Nida Ahmad, Meerut-born actress Archana Gautam and the party's own flock: Pankhuri Pathak, vice-chairperson (social media) and Mahila Congress leaders Mamata Chaudhary, Shamina Shafique and Shehla Arhari.

The Congress has also released a separate manifesto for women, promising 40 per cent reservation for women in government jobs, besides freebies for girl students, a tactic everyone from Bihar CM Nitish



INTERVIEW | PRIYANKA GANDHI

"Creating a new paradigm in UP politics by giving 40% tickets to women"

The two main rivals in Uttar Pradesh–BJP and Samajwadi Party–are busy stitching up coalitions based on caste calculations. The Congress, meanwhile, has introduced a novel element: gender. Women constitute 46 per cent of the state's population, and the Grand Old Party has promised this segment 40 per cent of its tickets in the upcoming poll. Congress general secretary in charge of UP **Priyanka Gandhi** calls it the foundation for a new discourse that will set the template for 2024 too. Excerpts from an interview with **Prashant Srivastava**

Q. Why has the Congress decided to go 'woman-centric' this election? What's behind the slogan '*Ladki hoon, lad sakti hoon*'?
It's not just a woman-centric campaign. We have many more aspects, including a push for youth, justice for farmers, fight against the backbreaking price rise...and the fact that we are running a positive, progressive campaign. We want to highlight our plans for UP's future, bringing issues of development, health, education, women's rights, benefits to farmers and social justice to the centre of the discourse. It's about time politics in India centred around development—issues that concern and benefit the public—rather than divisiveness and campaigns that thrive on negativity, benefiting only certain political parties.

Q. Why do you think people won't